as a cause of the conflict. Rather, the complexity of the conflict and the number of diverse actors suggest numerous opposing ways that power is framed and contested. For example, the political contests in the KIO/A and among civil society groups call for different processes of articulating actions and beliefs, while actors who have benefitted from the Kachin ceasefire (businessmen, militias, empowered local leaders) and the militia groups that have become de facto government forces have blurred the ethno-nationalist divisions.

Further examination of the emergence of a Kachin sense of identity as 'an ethnic group' will need to be the subject of another paper. The Kachin have a very strong sense of collective identity, which is surprising given their diverse subgroups, some only distantly related and sometimes with their own internal tensions. The collective experience of systematic discrimination and chauvinistic paternalism, however, bolsters the legitimacy of the separatist argument. This narrative of a clash of ideology does point to the issue of political rights and the distribution of power as fundamental and the quest for equality and freedom — only not solely along narrowly constructed 'ethnic' lines.

THE ROLE OF TERRITORY AND RESOURCES

If the Kachin conflict is fundamentally about processes of identification, with issues of political rights and the distribution of power perhaps fundamental, this raises the question of the role of territory and resources in the conflict. As noted in the introduction, the conflict has clearly morphed in recent years, with almost all violent clashes between the Tatmadaw and the KIA since 2011 now centred around the control of resources and resource trade corridors.

Territory is very significant to the Kachin we interviewed: even in Yangon many spoke passionately about the land and identify with Kachin State. The ideas of territory and nationalist identity were strongly connected, not as a mystical attachment to the land but based on cultural survival. As one diaspora academic said, "The idea of land and territory expresses life, the life of the people." Continuity of identity is seen to be linked to control of territory, making the value of territory mostly the ability to sustain cultural identity, through self-government and control over the resources required to sustain and develop Kachin society (Seng Maw Lahpai 2013).